

For me, an avid gamer, one of the biggest hoaxes has been the supposed deliverance that the DX10 was to bring about. For the first time, the industry saw hardware that was ahead of its time with a badly lagging software component. With rumours of DX10.1 and even DX11, it's hard to sort out what's fact and what's fiction. With gaming hardware, it's a lot easier—both NVIDIA and ATI have behaved themselves and wooed us consumers with some very good offerings. As always, the horizon looks greener still, with the likes of NVIDIA's unborn G100 and GT200 GPUs and ATIs RV770, which will sport next generation architectures. NVIDIA has two new launches that aren't available in the market at the time of writing this—the GeForce 9800GTX and the 9800GX2 the latter being a dual-PCB solution similar to the 7900GX2. From reports on the Web, the 9800GTX isn't the new high-end king by much, and its 256-bit memory interface seems a detraction from the 384-bit interface on the 8800GTX / Ultra. The only saving grace seems to be the 65 nm core running at 675 MHz; an overclocked 8800GT comes close to shaming it.

I was looking for three very different graphics card solutions—a budget solution, a good gaming solution and a dual GPU (SLI / Crossfire) solution. The dual-GPU solution was for

Shopping For More Action!

Agent goes on some serious graphic card shopping...

our office—we needed something fast for benchmarking. With no new releases expected from either vendor (NVIDIA and ATI) over the next few months and newer architectures expected after another six months, this is prime time for anyone looking for a good graphics solution. Waiting for newer stuff may seem sensible, but there's always going to be better hardware available in the future, so it's futile, really.

I needed a decent card for an HTPC. My budget for this card was Rs 4,000. My options were very limited—ATI's HD2400 Pro and NVIDIA's 8400GS seemed like the only two options for the price, both cards are available from a variety of brands. The prices are similar and range from Rs 2,700 to Rs 4,500. Also on offer was the GeForce 8500GT chipset based cards. ATI doesn't have any competing offering as its HD2600 Pro / XT is costlier, and competes with the GeForce 8600GT, both of these options exceed my budget. I decided on the 8400GS chipset, and the brand options were XFX, ASUS, MSI, Gigabyte, Sparkle, Leadtek, Galaxy and Palit. I ended up with a 256-MB version of Sparkle's 8400GS for just Rs 2,950 after haggling over the dealer-quoted price of Rs 3,050. Such a card takes a huge load off your CPU and system RAM while tackling video and HD video playback, and is worth the money considering that onboard solutions hog system memory.

For a single-card gaming solution, everyone seems to point towards the GeForce 8800GT or 9600GT. ATI's equivalent Radeon HD3870 is a little costly (Rs 12,000 at least) for the performance it gives, and the 8800GT is priced better and outperforms it. NVIDIA's 9600GT seems a real winner—it's twice as fast as the 8600GT with 64 shader units, and is priced in the range of Rs 9,000 to 10,000. It even outperforms the 8800GT (112 shader units) in some games at lower resolutions. The older 8800GTX / Ultra and HD2900XT aren't good buys, especially since the 8800GT comes within 15 per cent of their performance (at worst) at

less than half the price. ATI's HD 3850-based offerings are all priced around the Rs 10,000 mark, making the 8800GT seem even better since it's priced at only Rs 3,000 to 5,000 more. From amongst the other brands Gigabyte's 8800GT OC Edition caught my attention from amongst the crowd. This card features a copper heatpipe Zalman cooler that cools the core by an incredible 12 to 15 degrees Celsius below the stock cooler. With a core factory overclocked to 700 MHz (default being 600 MHz) and a price tag of Rs 12,000 only (my haggling skills failed miserably here), I'd have been a fool to look elsewhere.

For my dual-GPU solution, I was confused. SLI and CrossFire are restricting in the choice of motherboard. SLI seems better with a great core like an 8800GT to build on, but CrossFire has the advantage of greater efficiency for the second card, and two Radeon HD3870 cards in CF offer nearly 100 per cent more performance than a single card. But I didn't want to restrict myself to using only an SLI or CF board. Then I came across the 3870 X2 card (basically two HD3870 GPUs on a single PCB) and my wish was answered. A basic check showed this card to be faster than a GeForce 8800 Ultra by some 20 to 30 per cent. It's a power hungry monster too, and consumes nearly 240 watts on load. It's the most hassle free dual-GPU solution you'll find out there. There were only three brands available—ASUS, Sapphire and GeCube, and although MSI, Gigabyte and Powercolor also do ATI based cards they didn't have any of these mighty solutions. I picked up the Sapphire HD3870 X2 for 28,000 bucks and had the distinct pleasure of watching everyone staring agape at the big spender...office money, but then that's our secret... ■

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Ashwini Bavékar

U3, Me One

I want to buy a pendrive based on the U3 platform. Which size and model should I look at?

Anant Khilnani

Kingston and SanDisk are two very reliable brands that have U3-based products—I'd say look for a 4 GB drive. It should cost around 850 bucks. I'd give SanDisk preference over Kingston. A 2 GB drive will cost around 500 bucks, but 4 GB offers the best value for money right now.

More Power!

I want to know whether my newly assembled PC requires a new power supply. My configuration is:

Intel Core 2 Quad Q6600 Processor
WD Caviar SE16 SATA 250 GB HDD
XFX GeForce 8800GT 512 MB Graphic Card
ASUS P5K Premium WiFi AP Motherboard
2 GB DDR2 RAM Transcend Jet RAM

I have two small 5 cm fans which came with the motherboard. I use USB very frequently to connect phones, iPod and PSP. I use Windows Vista Ultimate SP1. My present PSU is a 400-W.

Saraansh Tandon

For this configuration, I doubt if even a regular 500 watt power supply would handle the job. You need something beefy that actually delivers its rated wattage. I recommend Corsair HX 520 Watts, which will cost around Rs 5,800. Or you could go for a CoolerMaster Extreme Power 650 Watts, which will cost Rs 3,800. Out of the two the Corsair will be overkill for your PC, but I feel it's better to have power in reserve than to have less power.

Amnesia

I bought an HP Pavilion tx1000 series notebook PC (TX 1301AU to be precise), with AMD Turion 64 x2 Mobile Technology TL-58 1.90 GHz, with 958 MB Memory (RAM), and 32-bit OS (Vista Home Premium) with Tablet PC functionality, on being reviewed in July edition of *Digit*. Now my problem with it is that its RAM is very low—the NVIDIA Graphics card is also sharing onboard memory and thus Vista hangs now and then. I need to buy at least 1 GB more memory. Which brands you suggest and recommend? My budget is up to Rs 2,000

Navrooz

Regardless of 1 GB of RAM, Vista shouldn't hang, could an outdated graphics card driver be the culprit? I suggest you update your drivers to the latest version and then check. Call HP's customer support and tell them the exact nature of the problem. You could also have an issue with a loose heatsink, but this is speculation unless we see the laptop for ourselves. That aside for upgrading your memory, I suggest you contact HP's customer support, as any kind of third party tampering will void any warranties. 1 GB of memory should cost you exactly Rs 2,000. An upgrade will bring about a moderate performance hike, but get those drivers updated pronto.

Visual Appeal

I want to buy a motherboard with inbuilt graphics processor. I have budget of Rs 7,500. Can these motherboards perform at par with the mid-range graphics card when playing games at medium resolutions? Also, I would like to know at what price Intel E6600 is retailing for now and I want to buy a 19-inch LCD monitor for my PC. Which one?

Aditya Narayan Ray

No onboard graphics solution will ever compete with even a low end graphics card of the same generation. I suggest a motherboard with no graphics solution and a cheap graphics card, preferably based on an entry level chipset like NVIDIA's GeForce 8400GS. Look at motherboards based on Intel's G35 graphics solution for around Rs 5000. Look at an Abit IP35 E for Rs 5,500 and a GeForce 8400GS for Rs 3,000, just overshooting your budget by a thousand—you'll get very good performance for even viewing HD movies, not to mention other multimedia options. The E6600 is phased out. The closest you can get to that is the new Penryn E8400 (3.0 GHz), which costs around Rs 10,000, or you could look at the cheaper and older E6750 (2.66 GHz) which should cost around Rs 8,000 bucks. As for your LCD monitor, flip over to our test.

Heading

I have a 3 GHz (HT) Pentium 4 on an ASUS Intel 865G chipset motherboard with 256 MB (2 x 128) PC3200 DDR RAM, a combo drive and 40 GB IDE HDD. I have decided to upgrade to 250 GB HDD, 1 GB DDR RAM and a DVD writer. My motherboard has no SATA ports. I've a budget of Rs 5,000. Please suggest the brands and their prices to look for. Also, tell me how to find out a hardware brand is genuine like a guarantee card. My vendor gives me a written bill with the guarantee period written by hand. Is he selling me original hardware or serviced stuff?

Manicka Raj

Let's take the last question first please—your vendor is giving you original stuff. In fact, most vendors like to mention the warranty period as stuff like hard drives come with varying warranties i.e. 3 years, 5 years and so on. It's very rare to find an 865G board with no SATA ports (if memory serves they used to have two slots), you must have been unlucky to get one of the rare models that didn't have a SATA port. However, if you meant Rs 5,000 for all the components including motherboard then you're out of luck. Your best bet would be to sell off your existing system, thereby getting a slightly larger budget to work with an investing in an LGA 775 based motherboard—an Intel G31 chipset-based board would be fine. For a processor, I recommend an E2160, a very cool processor that will cost you around 3,000 bucks. 1 GB of DDR2 667 MHz memory will cost around Rs 1,000. A blazing fast Seagate 7200.10 series single platter 250-GB SATA hard drive will cost you around 2,800 bucks. If you must stick with your existing socket 478 setup then look for another 865G based board with two SATA ports. 1 GB of DDR RAM will cost you around Rs 3,000.

Ask Away!

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